

PMD · Project Selection & Kickoff Protocol

Artifact #20 · v1.1 · May 2026 · PMD System · Applies to every project P1 through Pn

PURPOSE OF THIS PROTOCOL

What this is	The structured process that fires before Phase 1 of every new project. It establishes the project's north star — the what and why — before a single artifact is drafted or a single line of code is written. It replaces the blank page with a puzzle. It converts activation paralysis into forward motion.
Why it exists	Without a kickoff protocol, every project begins with the same disorienting moment: scope uncertainty, tool setup anxiety, and the absence of a clear ignition point. This protocol eliminates that moment by design. The project does not start with a task list. It starts with a problem to solve.
The core mechanic	Puzzle-framing triggers intrinsic motivation by appealing to the problem-solver identity. The specific skills and tools required for this project are introduced by the coach as clever solutions to the problem — named explicitly but framed as what they make possible, not what they demand. The user encounters those tools again during Phase 5 PRD, where they become owned requirements.
Project scope — not phase scope	This protocol is scoped to an individual project — P019, P063, P145 — not to a categorical phase. Phase context may appear as orientation background within the Project Context Brief, but the brief itself is always anchored to the specific project's problem and goals. A project number is the unit of work. A phase is a grouping of units.
When it runs	Once per project. Always before Phase 1 Discovery fires. The output is the project's North Star Document — a single locked artifact that every subsequent phase refers back to when scope questions arise.
Design principle	From JTBD Artifact #5, Design Principle 1: One prompt, one answer, one step. This protocol delivers exactly one question at a time. The next step only appears after the current one is answered.

PROTOCOL OVERVIEW — FIVE STEPS

Step	Name	Who leads	Output	Time
1	Project Context Brief	Coach delivers	Project-specific goals, skill targets, and tool set framed as outcomes	5 min
2	The Ignition Prompt	Coach delivers User responds	Three project options presented. User selects, adapts, or proposes alternative.	10–20 min
3	Project Evaluation	Coach + User	Selected project scored against four criteria. Classification and deployment track locked.	10 min
4	North Star Document	Coach drafts User approves	One-page locked north star: what, why, success definition, constraints, deployment track.	10 min

5	Kickoff Checklist	User completes	Repository initialized, tools confirmed, content log created, Phase 1 ready to fire.	10 min
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Step 1 — Project Context Brief

Before the ignition prompt fires, the coach delivers a brief orientation to the specific project being kicked off — not to the phase category it belongs to. The brief is anchored to this project's number, problem space, and goals. Phase context may appear as a one-sentence orientation — for example, 'This project sits within the collaboration layer of Phase IV' — but the brief immediately narrows to the project itself. The brief answers three questions for this specific project: What capability does this project build that the previous project did not have? What does the product look like when this project is done that it does not look like right now? And what are the one or two new skills and tools this project is specifically designed to introduce? Crucially: skills and tools are named explicitly and introduced by the coach — not hidden or withheld. The user cannot independently identify 'WebSockets' as the solution to a real-time presence problem without prior exposure. The coach names the tool, explains what it makes possible, and frames it as the clever solution to the problem the project is trying to solve. The user then encounters those tool names again in Phase 5 PRD, where writing them as technical requirements makes them owned rather than assigned.

PROJECT CONTEXT BRIEF — TEMPLATE

Project number & phase context	State the project number (e.g. P019) and one sentence of phase orientation if relevant: 'P019 sits within Phase III — the first time the product owns its own authentication layer.' Phase context is background, not the focus. The brief is always about this project.
The capability gap	Before this project, the product cannot [X]. After this project, it can [X]. The gap may reference phase-level capability where it adds context — e.g. 'This closes the gap between a managed auth service and full ownership of every token, cookie, and reset flow — the core challenge of Phase III's backend ownership arc.' But the gap is always stated at the project level.
What it makes possible	Two or three concrete outcomes a real user can experience — or a hiring evaluator can see — that were not possible before this project. Framed as outcomes, not features or tools.
Skills and tools introduced	Name the new skills and tools explicitly. For each, give one sentence: what it is, what problem it solves, and why it is the right tool for this project's specific challenge. Example: 'WebSockets — a persistent two-way connection between browser and server — is what makes real-time updates possible without the user refreshing the page.' The user will write these into the PRD technical requirements in Phase 5.
Connection to prior project	One sentence on what this project builds on from the previous one. Reinforces the compounding nature of the journey. Makes each project feel like progress, not a restart.

Step 2 — The Ignition Prompt

We need to create a project that [solves this specific problem / builds this capability]. Here are three options that could work: Option A — [Project concept: different domain] Option B — [Project concept: different domain] Option C — [Project concept: different domain] Which of these sounds most appealing to you? Do you have a fourth or fifth option to suggest? How could your chosen option be commercialized or genuinely help others?

IGNITION PROMPT — DESIGN MECHANICS

Why three options	Three options prevents the blank page without creating false constraint. If none of the three resonate, the fourth or fifth option the user generates is always more intrinsically motivated than a coach-assigned project. The coach's three options are puzzle seeds, not mandates.
Options differ by domain	The three options must address meaningfully different problem spaces and user types — not just different names for the same concept. A project exploring real-time collaboration for writers, a project tracking live sports data, and a project showing live inventory updates are three genuinely different puzzles that all happen to require WebSockets. Domain choice drives motivation.
Skills and tools appear in the prompt	The Project Context Brief already named the new skills and tools. The ignition prompt reinforces them naturally by embedding them in the problem framing: 'This project needs to push live updates to every connected user the moment something changes — that's the real-time challenge WebSockets is built to solve.' The tool is the hero of the solution, not an item on a prerequisites list.
Why the commercialization question	The commercialization question fires a second ignition layer by connecting the project to real-world relevance immediately. For someone with business fluency and product vision, 'how could this genuinely help others' is an identity-level motivator, not a hypothetical. It also surfaces portfolio potential early — before any work is done.
What the coach prepares	Before delivering the ignition prompt, the coach reviews the roadmap scope and tools for this specific project position, then drafts three concepts that all satisfy the project's required skill and tool targets. Preparation takes five minutes. The prompt should feel effortless to receive.

Step 3 — Project Evaluation

Once a project concept is selected or proposed, it is scored against four criteria before it is locked. This is a ten-minute conversation, not a form. The coach asks each question, the user responds, and both agree before moving to Step 4. Step 3 also locks the deployment track — Portfolio/Public or Learning/Internal — which determines which checklist items apply in Step 5.

THE FOUR EVALUATION CRITERIA

Criterion	The Question	Pass	Fail → Action
1 Stretch Fit	Does this project introduce the skills and tools identified in the Project Context Brief — without requiring capabilities from phases not yet reached?	Introduces phase tools. Builds on prior tools as foundation.	Too advanced: simplify the concept or defer it to a later project slot.
2 Stall Risk	Is the scope small enough to maintain momentum — completable without triggering the overwhelm loop?	Feels like a stretch. Does not feel like a wall.	Too large: identify the MVP slice. Document the rest as a future project or iteration.
3 Classification	Would a hiring evaluator feel this project's problem is relevant to their company? Or is this primarily a skill-building exercise?	Portfolio: evaluator-relevant. Showcased on thepmdev.com.	Learning: internal only. Valuable but not publicly showcased. Document the classification.
4 Commercial Potential	Is there a real-world user who would benefit from this product? Could it be monetized, open-sourced, or productized — even hypothetically?	A real person with a real problem. Commercialization path imaginable.	No clear user: rephrase the problem or select a different concept from the ignition options.

DEPLOYMENT TRACK DECISION — LOCKED AT STEP 3

Classification determines the deployment track. Not every project requires a public deployment. Internal learning projects are built, documented, and committed to GitHub — but do not require their own domain or hosted environment. This decision is locked here and drives which checklist items apply in Step 5.

Track	When it applies	Deployment required	thepmdev.com
Portfolio / Public	Project classified as Portfolio · OR · project is commercializable and warrants public access · OR · project is explicitly designated as a standalone showcase	Yes — Netlify or equivalent. CI/CD pipeline connected. Custom domain or thepmdev.com subdirectory.	Showcased on thepmdev.com when full launch trigger is met (P0 v2 + 3 portfolio projects live).
Learning / Internal	Project classified as Learning · AND · not designated as a public showcase · AND · no commercialization path is being actively pursued	No public deployment required. Code committed to GitHub. Local dev environment sufficient.	Not showcased publicly. May be referenced in the PMD journey log or reading tracker as evidence of progression.

thepmdev.com Living Repository Appendix — P0 v2 Backlog Item: A dedicated navigation section on thepmdev.com housing all projects as a living appendix — showing titles, project numbers, phase groupings, skills demonstrated, and build dates — would make internal learning projects publicly visible as evidence of progression without requiring individual deployments. This is logged as a P0 v2 backlog item and does not block any current project.

Step 4 — The North Star Document

The North Star Document is the single locked artifact establishing the project's what and why before Phase 1 fires. It is one page. It is approved before any other artifact is created. Every subsequent phase refers back to it when scope questions arise. It is not a PRD — the PRD comes in Phase 5 and expands on the north star. It is directional, not prescriptive. It is the flag on the mountain. Phase 1 Discovery is the first step toward it.

NORTH STAR DOCUMENT — TEMPLATE

Field	What to write
Project number & name	The project number from the roadmap (e.g. P019) and the name chosen during the ignition prompt. The name describes the product or problem — not the tools used to build it.
The problem being solved	One paragraph written in the voice of the user, not the builder. Who has this problem, what is the cost of not solving it, and why does it persist today.
The proposed solution	One paragraph stating what this project builds and — equally important — what it does not build. The 'does not build' line is the scope boundary. It prevents drift through all nine phases.
Definition of done	Three to five specific, observable conditions that mean this project is complete. Not 'the app works.' Concrete and testable: 'A user can create an account, log in from a mobile browser, see their dashboard, and log out without errors or broken layout.'
Skills and tools targeted	The three to five capabilities this project is specifically designed to build, framed as 'after this project I will be able to [X].' The specific tools named in the Project Context Brief are listed here by name. These become the technical requirements section of the Phase 5 PRD.
Classification	Learning (internal only) or Portfolio (showcased on thepmddev.com). Locked here. Reclassification requires documented rationale in the retrospective.
Deployment track	Portfolio/Public or Learning/Internal. Locked at Step 3. Determines which checklist items apply and whether a public deployment is required.
Commercial potential note	One sentence on who this could serve beyond the builder and how. Learning projects include this line to keep product thinking active throughout the build.
Coaching mode	The calibration level confirmed for this project per the PMD coaching scale. Stated explicitly so both coach and user begin from the same expectation.
Content log initialized	Confirmation that docs/content-log/ exists in the repository and the four Artifact-to-Draft bucket files are ready: decisions.md · failures.md · metrics.md · user-insights.md

Step 5 — Kickoff Checklist

The kickoff checklist is the gate between the protocol and Phase 1 Discovery. It takes ten minutes and makes the project real. Every unchecked box is a future blocker surfaced before it becomes a stall. The checklist has two tracks. Complete the Universal section for every project. Then complete either the Portfolio/Public track or the Learning/Internal track based on the deployment decision locked in Step 3.

UNIVERSAL — Every project, every track

- New GitHub repository created with name matching the North Star Document
- README.md initialized with project number, name, phase context, and one-line problem statement
- NOTES.md created for open items, technical debt, and deferred decisions
- docs/ folder created with subdirectories: current/ · archive/ · content-log/
- Content log bucket files initialized: decisions.md · failures.md · metrics.md · user-insights.md
- .gitignore configured for this project's expected tech stack
- First commit pushed — repository is live on GitHub
- PMD_SKILL.md and current session summary confirmed available for this session context
- North Star Document filed to docs/current/ and approved by both user and coach
- All new tools required for this project confirmed installed or accounts created
- .env.example created with all required variable names — no values committed
- Classification locked: Learning or Portfolio
- Deployment track locked: Portfolio/Public or Learning/Internal
- Coaching mode confirmed for this project
- First Tier-1 Build Log post drafted for the project selection decision itself

PORTFOLIO / PUBLIC TRACK

Complete when deployment track = Portfolio/Public

- Netlify (or equivalent hosting) connected to GitHub repository
- CI/CD pipeline confirmed: local commit → GitHub push → auto-deploy → live URL
- Custom domain or thepmdev.com subdirectory configured and resolving correctly
- Google Analytics 4 measurement ID installed in index.html or _app
- Microsoft Clarity tracking script installed
- WCAG 2.2 Level AA compliance confirmed as a Phase 7 build requirement
- thepmdev.com showcase slot noted in P0 v2 backlog once full launch trigger conditions are met

LEARNING / INTERNAL TRACK

Complete when deployment track = Learning/Internal

- Local development environment confirmed running without errors
- GitHub repository is the deployment artifact — no public hosting required
- Project noted in the PMD journey log and skills tracker as in-progress
- If commercialization potential emerges during the build: flag for reclassification in retrospective

PMD SYSTEM INTEGRATION — SKILL.MD ADDITION

The following rules are added to PMD_SKILL.md immediately after the COACHING RULES — PERMANENT section and before COACHING CALIBRATION. They are permanent and non-negotiable.

Before every project	The five-step Project Selection & Kickoff Protocol runs in full. No project begins at Phase 1 without a completed North Star Document and a passed Kickoff Checklist. Applies to P1 through Pn without exception.
Project Context Brief	The brief is scoped to the individual project — P019, P063 — not the categorical phase. Phase context may appear as a one-sentence orientation. The brief is always anchored to this specific project's number, problem, and goals.
Skills and tools are named	The coach names all new skills and tools explicitly in the Project Context Brief. Each is framed as the clever solution to a specific problem the project faces. The user writes them into the Phase 5 PRD technical requirements, which is when ownership transfers from coach to builder.
The ignition prompt rule	Three meaningfully different project options presented — different domains, not just names. User selects, adapts, or proposes a fourth or fifth. Coach never assigns unilaterally. Commercialization question is always included.
Deployment track	Portfolio/Public or Learning/Internal. Locked at Step 3. Portfolio projects require full CI/CD deployment and WCAG 2.2 AA. Learning projects require only a GitHub repository and local dev environment. Reclassification requires documented rationale in the retrospective.
North Star is scope authority	When scope questions arise during any phase, the North Star Document is the authority. The PRD in Phase 5 expands on it — it does not contradict it.
Reference artifact	Artifact #20 · Project Selection & Kickoff Protocol v1.1 · May 2026

VERSION HISTORY

Version	Key changes	Date
v1.0	Initial protocol — five steps, ignition prompt, four evaluation criteria, North Star Document template, kickoff checklist	May 2026
v1.1	Five clarifications applied: (1) Renamed Phase Context Brief to Project Context Brief — scoped to individual project number, not categorical phase. (2) Capability Gap field updated to clarify phase language is permitted as orientation context only. (3) Skills and tools are now explicitly named by coach and framed as problem solutions — not hidden — with PRD Phase 5 as the ownership transfer point. (4) Deployment made conditional — two-track checklist: Portfolio/Public and Learning/Internal. thepmdev.com living appendix logged as P0 v2 backlog item. (5) Panic word references removed throughout.	May 2026

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